

Praise of the Supremely Exalted

Viśiṣṭastava · Toh 1109 · Derge Tengyur

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Toh 1109 in the Tengyur is a devotional hymn known in Sanskrit as the Viśiṣṭastava and in Tibetan as the Khyad par du 'phags pa'i bstod pa, meaning "The Praise of the Supremely Exalted." It is a stotpa, or praise poem, addressed to the Buddha, celebrating his unparalleled qualities by contrasting them with the attributes of Hindu deities such as Viṣṇu and Śiva, whose celebrated powers the author reinterprets as defects when measured against the Buddha's wisdom and compassion. The text belongs to the broad category of laudatory literature found in the Tengyur and reflects the classical Indian Buddhist tradition of demonstrating the supremacy of the Dharma through reasoned and poetic comparison with rival religious traditions.

In the language of India: Viśiṣṭastava. In the language of Tibet: The Praise of the Supremely Exalted. Homage to all the Tathāgatas.

I have turned away from all other teachers
and come to you, O Blessed One, for refuge.
Why is this? Because you are free of fault
and endowed with excellent qualities.

Since the world delights in faults
and clings to what it takes as good qualities,
it sees even faults as though they were virtues
and so goes to others for refuge.

Viṣṇu and Śiva (Skt. Maheśvara) and the like —
people take delight and faith in them,
and whatever qualities are proclaimed for those gods
are, by the measure of your teaching, mere faults.

The Great God (Śiva) is said to have burned down
the triple city with a single arrow of wrath,
but with the great arrow of your wisdom
you have thoroughly burned the very mind of anger.

The Great God drew desires back toward himself
after burning them — and thus did further harm.
By the penetrating force of your wisdom,

you cut desire out by the root, burned it, and cast it away.

The Great God, aroused with attachment for
the supreme drop (Śakti), grew four faces.

But the coquettish daughter of Māra
could not stir even the tip of your body hair.

The Great God was powerless even before his younger wife,
unable to overcome her even with a cry of longing.

But you, O Sage, were never deluded
by the desires that bring pleasure.

Those with wheel-tipped spears could not overcome
the power of Māra's forces.

But you, with no spear and no wheel,
conquered through the weapon of loving-kindness.

They say the old man Viṣṇu was pierced by an arrow,
and the Great God's throat turned blue from the poison —
these two gods suffer harm.

But you, O Protector, are utterly free of harm.

Viṣṇu took on a dwarfish form
and by that stratagem deceived the powerful one.
But you know all deception,
and yet you do not deceive others in turn.

O Protector, what you take up is only miraculous power;
the wondrous feat by which you are seen —
Viṣṇu crossing the three worlds —
is seen as no more than a small frog jumping.

While still a youth living the holy life,
Brahmā is said to have consorted with the six-limbed goddess.
But you reduced the seven postures of intercourse
to ashes.

Brahmā and those like him are said to proclaim
that they alone are the creators of the world.
But you, seeing reality as it is, taught
that the world too arises from karma.

Śakra (Indra), they say, saw the unblemished one
and was maddened by desire.

But you, O Brave One, so as not to be maddened
by desire itself, sent away a queen.

Even the moon is helplessly swallowed
by the hand of Rāhu.

But there is no sentient being
that you, O sovereign, render powerless.

The king of men went back to the forest
seeking pleasure-giving garments and the like.

But you, O Sugata, intoxicated by the nectar
of solitude, never return from it.

The sages are said to declare that animals are slaughtered
in the fire-sacrifice.

But you, O sinless one, do not permit
harm even to an ant.

Others, for their own sake in sacrifice,
offer the lives of other beings in the fire.

For the sake of others, you alone
offered your own life in the fire-offering.

The unbearable fire of a sage's curse
is said to burn many people.

But with the fire of your wisdom
you burn the causes of arising in all beings.

It is heard that Brahmā, through the weakness
of his recollecting power while recounting
the expanded teachings, spoke many words
that contradicted one another front and back —
but for you, the Sage, there is no such failure.

From the accomplishment of a sage's curse,
one infers accomplishment through austerity.

But from you, O Protector, through the accomplishment of compassion,
one infers accomplishment through austerity.

The Great God, bearer of the mark of one consumed by desire,
fell through the curse of the sages.

But you have caused the very root of all ruin and disorder —
desire itself — to fall away.

For the most part, things such as "born from an island" and the like —
whatever others say, so they are made to say.

You taught the uncommon Dharma
having realized it within yourself.
The words of the tīrthikas' sacred texts
they utter only in seclusion.

You proclaimed it, and with the lion's
roar you taught those Dharmas.
The Sāṃkhya master Bharadvāja,
though he saw that very reality, yet in spring —
utterly attached, his chief disciple too
did not refrain from women.

The owl-priest taught: give
to the distinguished rather than the lowly.
But you, O Protector, through compassion,
taught that one should give even to a dog.

The naked ascetics sought to undo the knot
through bodily austerity.
But you, O Protector, hold that the knot
is to be undone through the austerity of the mind.

The logicians seek to establish things
as existing without dependence.
But you, the master of words, taught well
that there is not even the slightest thing that is not dependent.

It is proclaimed that Netso, having pierced the sun,
taught that liberation is thereby attained.
But you attained nirvāṇa
and went nowhere at all.

Liberation arose in another's stream of being,
and Netso went by a different path.
The very path by which you yourself departed —
by that very path the disciple too comes.

The Viṣṇus seized sixty thousand women.
But you, the Teacher who has transcended the world,
have no self and no one seized.

To Kāśī's beautiful Pramudā,
abundance becomes the cause of complete attachment.
Though you dwelt as a householder,
your faculties were not confused by the demon of intoxicating bewilderment.
Abundance, tormented by desire and lust,
was pierced by a woman's sharp goad.
But you, even dwelling as a householder,
were not one to be troubled and thrown into disorder from without.

It is proclaimed that for the sake of his beloved wife
one crossed to the far shore of the ocean.
But you abandoned eighty thousand women
and departed to the forest.

Viṣṇu began to harm beings
such as Rāvaṇa and others who were difficult to overcome.
But you, wishing to benefit sentient beings,
gave up even your own life.

What Viṣṇu seized by deception
with three steps —
that very ground you held to be in need of liberation,
and you relinquished it down to the very root.

Pramudā, through the arrow that kills,
having rid the world of its warrior lineage,
whatever fame was gained thereby —
that fame belongs not to your teaching.

The glory of battle's din and clamorous cry —
for the sake of which one arrays for war —
that glory you renounced like poison,
pulling it away and departing.

When your teaching was encountered,
the Great God (Śiva), who dwells in the forest of Śāla trees —
that sovereign of yogins and his conduct —
he acted in ignorance of it.

The brahmins still to this day proclaim:
"The lord of the senses is a rat without a plough."

But the fame of your having attained the supreme fruit
was proclaimed by Śakra (Indra).

The Viṣṇus, bewildered and confounded by the tiger's cry,
entered beneath the throne of Kuntu-gō,
and none had the power to restrain you, O Chief.

It is heard that the lord of creatures lay
with his own daughter.

Yet even your disciples, O Sage,
are blameless in their pure conduct.

The brahmins teach that virtue and non-virtue
are transferred through the giving and receiving of gifts.
But you taught that what has been done does not go to waste,
and that what has not been done cannot be encountered.

The yellow-robed ones examined carefully
the defining marks of the self.
You taught that if that were so, then the self
would be possessed of impermanence.

The fire-eaters distinguished the self from consciousness,
declaring it wholly other.
You taught that if it lacked consciousness,
it would absurdly follow that it is like a piece of wood.

The naked ones teach that the vital force
contracts and expands according to the measure of the body.
You taught that it would in that case
be annihilated in one direction.

The brahmins taught that the cause of all beings
is a permanent person.
You taught that there is no such thing
as a cause that is permanent.

The sixty thousand sons
of the great self-existent one, filled with poison —

were burned by the mere glance of the yellow-robed ones.
Yet toward them too you showed compassion.
Those same yellow-robed ones, through their sacred knowledge,
taught that beings arise from a supreme lord.
But you proclaimed that the arising of beings
comes from afflictions and karma.
The yellow-robed ones and others say
that their liberation-self is the cause of continued existence.

After you passed into peace,
those who entered and perished became beyond counting —
like flames gone out.
Some among the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say
that liberation involves going somewhere.
But you, having fully understood,
taught that wherever there is going, there is saṃsāra.

The naked ones say that pleasure-groves, walls,
and such things are causes of sin.
But you, omniscient one, yourself
declared those same things to be causes of merit.

It is proclaimed that a subtle vital force
migrates from body to other bodies.
But you taught that there exists
no vital force that is other than the body.

Those who follow the Brahmins say that if one kills in battle out of anger,
one goes to a happy realm.
But you, O Protector, taught that
the mind at such a moment leads to a lower realm.

Some say that if one recites the names of the grey-robed wanderers,
it becomes meritorious — each in their own tradition.
But those who travel what cannot be traveled,
those practitioners — they despise your teaching.

Śiva, the Fierce One (Rudra), and others
carry weapons always, out of fear,
to threaten and to intimidate.
But you are free of all fear and do not threaten.
Since no one frightens you,

and you threaten no one,
you alone bear no weapon —
and thus you are supreme among beings.

The words of afflicted speakers,
the texts of the Vedas and the like,
are for the most part contradictory, top to bottom.
But your speech, the words of omniscience,
unlike the treatises of others,
which are mostly contradictory from beginning to end,
your own system of teaching
is faultless from start to middle to finish.

They say that the Dharma, if desired,
should not be given to the common folk.
But you, out of compassion,
taught the sacred Dharma even to outcastes.

Who would seek refuge in a bad tree
after abandoning good ones?
If you, who have attained freedom from attachment, remain,
what wise person would bow to another teacher?

The yellow-robed ones, while still engaged with sense objects,
claim they are transformed into wisdom, freed from sin.
But you taught: while still fully immersed in afflictions,
how can there be liberation?

As for the accumulation of merit accumulated by wholesome deeds —
you, O Blessed One, taught that it is to be wholly dedicated to all sentient
beings.

This is not stated in the treatises of others.

Those who kill sentient beings for shrines and for sacrificial offerings —
the worldly seek Dharma in such things.
But in your teaching, those practices are condemned.

One who perpetually harms living creatures —
how can they have the nature of Dharma?
But you, O Chief, out of care for your own life,
protected sentient beings well.

Born of the Śākya royal lineage, you yourself
held truthfulness, non-deception,
pure conduct, self-restraint,
and tenderness to be the sacred Dharma.

Though those steeped in the Vedas say
that enemies coming openly in battle should be killed,
you taught that even toward enemies
one should show compassion.

The young man, it seems, was ordered
to thrust a spear into his own maternal uncle.
But you, O Hero, cut through
the net of afflictions with the weapon of wisdom.

Viṣṇu could not even protect
his own younger brother fully.
But you, O Chief, strove
to bring protection to all sentient beings.

When he learned of the danger devised by the elder,
Viṣṇu was overcome and lost everything.
As for any being that would feel pity for you, O Sage —
there is none.

Viṣṇu met his dear ones in battle
and was struck by them in return.
But all your own dear ones
you liberated completely from saṃsāra.

In the system of the non-Buddhists —

The more and more I reflect upon you,
O Protector, the more and more
my mind is filled with faith.

Thus those who hold the doctrinal flaw
of not being omniscient —
those whose thinking is ruined by such views —
they cannot see you, O Teacher,
who are completely without fault.

As for the gods of this world, the brahmins,
the Vedas, and the Śākyas — when people speak

of these with hostility, calling them this and that,
that fault lies with themselves alone.
Why do they think in this way?

It is because your teaching, O Teacher,
is what leads beings from happiness to happiness itself.
For this reason, O Lion among speakers,
the beings of this world delight in your tradition.

By thus fully proclaiming the true qualities
you possess in this manner,
may whatever merit I have thereby gained
make me, in the world of wandering beings, someone like you.

The Praise Called "Utterly Exalted" — the virtuous merit I have gathered
by composing it, whatever that may be:
may all wandering beings through that merit
turn toward the path of awakening.

The Praise Called "Utterly Exalted," composed by the master the venerable
Siddharāja, is complete.

Translated by the Indian paṇḍita Sarvajñādeva together with the great-editor
translator, the monk Rinchen Chok. Subsequently retranslated, revised, and
finalized by the monk Paltsek Rakṣita.

Translator's Notes

- The text is the Viśiṣṭastava, a hymn of praise attributed to Udbhaṭasiddhasvāmin, contrasting the Blessed One favorably with Brahmanical deities. Several stanzas allude to well-known Purāṇic myths whose references I note here.

The stanza about the "Great God, aroused by the supreme drop" alludes to Śiva's desire for a supremely beautiful Śakti figure, which caused him to grow a fourth face. The "drop" renders this le, here used in a Purāṇic rather than tantric sense.

The stanza about "the six-limbed goddess" alludes to Brahmā's incestuous passion for Śatarūpā or a similar figure; "six-limbed" likely refers to a goddess associated with the ṣaḍaṅga tradition, though the exact identification is uncertain.

The final stanza about "born from an island" is an allusion to Vyāsa (Dvaipāyana, "born from an island"), hinting that Purāṇic teachings are derivative fabrications. The abrupt ending suggests this is the opening section of a longer work.

- The figure "Netso" is an obscure name, likely a transliteration of a non-Buddhist teacher. The text states that this figure claimed liberation through "piercing the sun," possibly a reference to a solar contemplative or ritual technique. The doctrinal contrast being drawn is that Netso's

liberation was in another's stream of being, while the teacher himself went by a different path, whereas the Buddha's disciples follow his very own path.

"Kuntu-gö" in the line about the throne is a Tibetan rendering of a name; it may refer to a local figure or deity. The passage is slightly obscure at that point.

The phrase rendered "tiger's cry" for "nag bkra bo" is uncertain: it may refer to a striped or variegated animal, possibly a tiger or a term of abuse. The bewilderment of the Viṣṇu at this cry suggests a scene of divine humiliation. This is noted as the identification is not certain.

"Kāśī's beautiful Pramudā" and "Pramudā" in the later verse: the name likely refers to a figure associated with the city of Kāśī (Vārāṇasī) in a narrative being contrasted with the Buddha's conduct.

- The passage refers to several recognizable figures and schools. The "yellow-robed ones" are the Sāṃkhya philosophers, whose traditional color is yellow and who teach that beings arise from a supreme lord (Īśvara or Pradhāna). The "grey-robed wanderers" likely refer to Ājīvika or related ascetic teachers. The episode concerning Viṣṇu and his brother alludes to the Mahābhārata narrative, where Arjuna (here "the young man") is commanded to fight his maternal uncle and where Viṣṇu's (Kṛṣṇa's) kin perished in the Yādava civil war; the poem uses these episodes polemically to contrast the Buddha's universal compassion with the limitations of the Hindu deity. The phrase rendered "those who enter and perish, beyond counting, like flames gone out" draws on a standard Tibetan metaphor for those who die in non-Buddhist ways without attaining liberation. The line about the "liberation-self as cause of existence" reflects the Sāṃkhya concept of the puruṣa. The translation of "Śiva, the Fierce One" renders the Tibetan "Skems byed dbang po nye dbang po drag po" — these are epithets referring to Rudra-Śiva; some ambiguity remains in the precise identification of each epithet as a separate deity or as a list of Śiva's names.

- The colophon title "Khyad par du 'phags pa'i bstod pa" is standardly rendered "Praise Called Utterly Exalted" or "Viśeṣastava" in Sanskrit; this is consistent with the established title of the text attributed to the master Udbhaṭasiddhasvāmin, here given as "Mthobtsun grub rje," a Tibetan rendering of that name. The identification is standard in the tradition.

The phrase "from happiness to happiness" renders "bde bas bde nyid thob bgyid pa," which carries the sense that the teaching leads beings from the happiness of this life through successive higher happinesses to liberation itself — a classical formulaic expression.